William Stephenson
Bowdoin, '77
F869.S3.S83

The Bancroft Library
University of California, Berkeley
Berkeley, California 94720-6000

The Bancroft Library
University of California, Berkeley

F869.S3.S83

Bowdoin, '77

Bowdoin, '77.

The following letter from Major Stephenson, though personal in form, was meant for the members of the Class of '77. It was written at the suggestion of your Secretary, who was sure that all the class would be interested in the experience of one of our number who was personally present during the terrible catastrophe at San Francisco — the greatest that has ever befallen an American city.
J. E. C.

PRESIDIO OF SAN FRANCISCO, CAL.
May 31, 1906.

My dear John, — Thank you heartily for the sympathy and interest expressed in your recent letter.... I am glad to give you a brief account of my personal experiences. As I had been rather habituated to earthquakes in the Philippines, I was not particularly alarmed at 5.13 A. M., April 18, when all buildings near the coast in California, for about three hundred miles, shook as they never shook before. I woke to find my bed sliding about on its castors; to feel our two-and-a-half story frame house jerking, swaying and groaning like a ship in a heavy sea, and to hear pictures, glass, china and bric-a-brac crashing all over the house. The rattle and thud of bricks and chimneys on the roof sounded like thunder, the noise in each house masking that out of doors and in adjacent houses. I lay in bed, expecting any jerk to be the last, but that forty-seven seconds seemed an eternity.

As most people are asleep at that hour, few witnessed the fearful spectacle that was going on outside. The shade to my sister's window fell, and she saw the swaying of the trees, the falling of our own and neighboring chimneys, as well as the churning of the sea in the Golden Gate.

After assuring myself of the safety of my sisters in the second story, I called to Lee Jim, our Chinese cook. He replied in a stolid way, and gravely inquired if I expected guests for luncheon, as I had intimated the day before. Sleeping in the basement, he got a minimum of the shock and took it as a matter of course. He said, “That's all right — the cow she turn over,” referring to the Chinese belief that the earth is supported on the back of a dragon, and so subject to the occasional vagaries of such a monster. Jim's kitchen is his castle, and we actually had to threaten to shoot him to keep him from cooking in his cook stove, thereby risking fire from the shattered chimney. Such slaves, and usually admirable ones, are they to routine!

The wreckage on the main floor was worse, as the house seemed to have rocked more near its foundations. Floors and rugs were strewn thickly with soot from the fireplaces, fallen plaster, broken glass from pictures, lamp shades and vases of flowers. A tall bookcase was flat on its face; the front door jammed and not to be

opened; the transom shattered above. Out doors a strange silence in the gray dawn, and a sky-line bereft of chimneys.

I went first to my Post Hospital, to find that about thirty soldiers were injured, some by falling bricks, but more from dropping from their second-story windows in their haste to get to the open air. Some had fractured legs, some sprains, and some cuts from broken glass.

The garrison naturally gravitated to the parade, and I found that the growing report of collapsed buildings and fires in the city had prompted General Funston and Colonel Morris to send in all available soldiers. So they marched away with their rifles for patrolling and their wagons of explosives for blowing up buildings, and the prompt appearance of our troops was all that saved the city from the terror of a mob, plundering, first, the saloons, of which there were 3,400, and then the stores and mansions.

After a hasty breakfast, cooked camp-fashion on the lawn, in a fireplace made from the bricks of fallen chimneys, I went again to my hospital and prepared for the reception of the sick and injured, which, before night, exceeded all previous experience. Refugees began to struggle into the post, feeling safer under the protecting arms of Uncle Sam. A distinguished retired general of our army, an old friend, came to us with his wife, sitting on their trunks in an army wagon. Friends drifted in the second day, after a night in the parks, with their hand-bags and what wraps they could carry. Our upstairs rooms were at a discount, and we turned our parlor into a dormitory for ladies, others camping on porch and lawn and reclining chairs in our living-room. Anonymous trunks were on our lawn for a week, disappearing as mysteriously as they came. You know that all railways, street cars, telephones, water and light service ceased at 5.13 o'clock on that Wednesday morning. Fortunately we had our own water system, which was not injured, so that the cooking outdoors for eight days was our main inconvenience in the Presidio.

Reports kept coming of this and that large building in town having collapsed, and startling rumors of wide-spread disaster throughout the United States, such as New York having been destroyed by earthquake and Chicago being under water. As the fire spread in the city toward the hospitals, their inmates poured out to this big army reservation, with its 1,500 acres of field and grove and its large, modern general hospital, and my small, old-fashioned Post Hospital.

Never before did the automobile have such a chance to show its splendid possibilities. Their owners readily gave them up for public service, and, all speed limits being removed, it was marvellous that so few accidents resulted. With thrice the speed of a horse, and unlimited endurance, some of them were in continuous use for eighty hours or more. With all communications gone, including wire, you can imagine their value in transporting military and fire chiefs, or their orders, dynamite, food and the sick and injured. One of the first from the fire brought an artillery lieutenant whose skull was fractured while blowing up a building; and so poured in the helpless from seven of the city hospitals with their nurses and followed up by their physicians, who have made a record for themselves in their devotion to the sick even while their own houses and offices were burning. My four wards filled up, my hospital corps lying down in the attic whenever a spare hour offered. Patients on litters and mattresses lay everywhere in the halls, porches and, finally, under the sky alone, with its ominous glare cityward and flying cinders. The prison ward, with its iron doors, was the only refuge for the maternity cases, and so the population of my little hospital kept at over two hundred for days.

The columns of smoke grew taller and grew together, and, with the sound of explosions, suggested a battle going on three miles away. About four P. M., my assistants being able to care for the post, I went down town with a returning motor, and to the famous Bohemian Club for what proved to be my last visit. An ominous quiet pervaded the club, the precious paintings were down and in the halls ready for hasty removal, and occasionally some dishevelled member would enter, more exhausted than he realized. At this time the fire had not overshadowed the earthquake, and comparisons with the historic shock of '68, and the shock-resisting strength of various constructions were in order among the old-timers and the architects respectively.

My uniform passed me through the fire lines to the corner of Market and Montgomery Streets, two blocks away, when I saw the grand old Palace Hotel in flames, as was all the south side of Market Street.

Then I walked along the boundaries of the fire, up Market Street to the City Hall, and Jefferson Park, already packed with refugees, and home, to find my household still growing. Despite the increasing glare to the east and approaching explosions, tired nature asserted herself, and I slept soundly in my room on the second story till wakened at dawn by refugees from the St. Francis Hotel, driven out during the night. Thursday, intensification of the same scene — everywhere. During the afternoon I rode in an auto to the scene of the great crisis of the fire — Van Ness Avenue. This wide north-and-south boulevard was the last hope when the easterly and main section of the city was seen to be doomed. Mayor Schmitz and General Funston, being the heads of the civic and military, who had worked together in perfect harmony since the beginning, had agreed to dynamite more than a mile of the best apartment houses and residences in the city, on the east side of Van Ness Avenue, but the fire outran the dynamiting. About 4 P. M. I saw the flames leap the avenue opposite two churches whose tall frontage threw a maximum of heat across. Then I saw St. Luke's church and three adjacent frame residences blown up. In one case only did it seem a total success. The large houses seemed to raise a trifle and then collapse, leaving their large chimneys looming up like spires. As on the preceding day, clubmen and other friends were about among the throng, looking the worse for wear, but with fight in their hearts and a special police star on their breasts. Among them there were millionaires whose houses were burning now, and whose business interests had gone up in smoke the day before. People were burying trunks and household goods in vacant lots. But the Presidio was on my mind, and I joined the great procession along the asphalt of Van Ness Avenue and Lombard Street. Such a pilgrimage! Anything on wheels — from a lawn mower to a hearse, from a baby carriage to a wagon — all piled high with goods, and whole families harnessed to horseless vehicles. Trunks were dragged for miles, but the most striking exhibit was that of a woman dragging by cords a sofa pillow with a parrot in its cage, fastened on with safety pins! The courage, the philosophy, the helpfulness, the sentimental saving of pets in lieu of more material possessions, were marvellous. A friend of mine, whose wife was away, saved only her canary of all their handsome furnishings. Another friend, who had his victoria and pair of horses, saved not one load, although his apartment did not burn for twenty-four hours after the earthquake. It seems incredible that thousands should save but their hand-bags. But the earthquake dazed and terrified people, and after the first flight the men did not dare to leave their families to go back, incredulous that the fire would reach their houses; then, when their houses were menaced, wagons were not to be hired, and the widely-spread rumors of dynamiting produced premature abandonment. Thursday night found us with the fire less than two miles away and the glare and detonations heavier. An army of pedestrians and vehicles poured into the Presidio reservation by the two main gates. Those fortunate enough to have motors came with them piled high with selected possessions — silver, family portraits, and rugs. Tents and piles of goods were everywhere. Ladies whom I had seen wearing diamond tiaras at the opera the night before the fire now occupied tents on our parade ground, as also did our commandant and other officers' families. About 2 A. M. Friday the dynamiting of five blocks on the east side of Franklin Street had stopped the progress of the fire towards us on the west, and the more modern resident section was saved, although the northeastern section of the city burned a day or two longer. When the fire was at its height we were alarmed by the fall of large cinders, some the size of a half-shingle, among our houses. It was reassuring to find them cold, but they kept us guessing, and many even in the garrison thought out which possessions should be saved first. I had a sailor among my hospital men, and he was stationed on the roof of the hospital, in his bare feet and with a fire extinguisher, over night. Between the loud detonations and the thought of the cinders I had little rest that night.

Since the fire, many refugees have gone into organized camps, and perhaps two hundred thousand have gone into the suburbs or scattered far and near. The piles of rugs and trunks of silver which filled the corners of our rooms and porches have been claimed and taken home, our chimneys rebuilt, but on a smaller scale, and the excitement is over, save when an unwelcome echo of the great *Tembler* (as the Spaniards call it) occurs. We

have had scores since April 18. Those of May 17 and last night were marked, but not harmful, save to nerves.

The earthquake alone would have been a notable event, but that damage alone, as you doubtless know, though wide-spread, amounted to but a few millions, and the inconvenience to the people would have been limited to a few days, but the fire left only the docks, a few United States buildings, and the new resident section, making a desert of about five square miles of the compact and busiest portion of the city. One wealthy real estate man owned eighty-one buildings in different parts of the city, and seventy-nine burned. The photographs seen all over our country are largely of the spectacular ruins from the shock, from poor foundations, on made ground and faulty construction. Brick walls suffered the most, though many buildings of that material, well braced with iron, are in good condition. The new hotels and business blocks of steel, terra-cotta and cement came through the earthquake uninjured. The average frame house, on solid ground, suffered only the loss of its chimneys and a varying amount of cracked and falling plaster.

The most terrifying experiences among my friends were among those in the upper stories of hotels and apartment houses. You can imagine that, upon being awakened in the early dawn by such an upheaval, to find your door blocked by a bureau leaning against it, or the door jammed, or the key shaken out and several feet away, one might develop a fine frenzy, and remain keenly alive to the occasional shakes we have had since. Fortunately, the splendid seaport is intact, and the passengers and cargoes come and go to the Orient as usual. An unequalled position and commerce insures to San Francisco her supremacy on the Pacific, and we shall see again a prosperous, well-built city, especially with such courage among its leading men. But the fascinating city of the past, with its pioneer and bohemian life, how can it ever be the same again? And now I must call a halt to this long letter. It is simply what I saw from my station in the northwest corner of the city. There are still many phases of discomfort and irritating inaction, more or less inevitable. The banks could not open their vaults for a month; the insurance problem is so serious that few claims have been paid yet. Hundreds of thousands are still cooking in the streets because chimney inspection is so slow, and though the street railroad people have been most energetic, they have perhaps but one fourth of their lines in operation. The death list has grown to about four hundred and fifteen, of whom probably not more than one third will ever have positive identification. Regretting that my extra work has delayed these notes, and again thanking you for your letter, believe me, as ever

Most truly yours
WILLIAM STEPHENSON.